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INTRODUCTION

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Purpose-in-action education: Introduction and implications

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ABSTRACT
Life purpose is a long-term aim to make one's life *count*. Education—especially moral education—might be considered a key cultural mechanism for young people to 'thread' their lives into the culture's 'bigger picture' not only of the 'good life' but also of a 'life of good.' How does life purpose relate to educationally important attributes like motivation, feedback, institutional support, and emotional engagement, especially education aimed to make salient the impacts students have on others? This introduction explores the implications of five papers from different countries regarding the challenges of *self-transcendence,* whether purpose is a *calling* from within or outside the self, and how purpose can pivot past-oriented reflection into *future-oriented proflection* that integrates students' educational experiences into their anticipated future life path. Given the multicultural frame on these topics and their implications, how can researchers and practitioners move forward in purpose education?

KEYWORDS
Youth purpose; culture; international; education; service-learning; teacher; reflection; calling; motivation; self-transcendence

Understanding life purpose through a cultural frame

Life purpose entails a person's self-defined superordinate aim to have a desired impact during one's lifespan not only in terms of gains for oneself but also through positive impacts on others, communities and institutions. This aim is so important to the person that it strongly influences intentions and efforts by organizing and prioritizing lower life goals, framing decisions and evaluating opportunities (Moran, 2017c). As purpose develops, four key dimensions integrate: personal meaningfulness, future intention, active engagement and beyond-the-self impact (Damon, 2008; Moran, 2014b).

This special issue on purpose-in-action education is part of a two-issue series on youth purpose internationally. The first issue published in September 2017 focused on the conception and experience of life purpose among youth in Brazil, Mongolia, South Africa, Iran, Thailand, Singapore, Israel and Japan. This second issue showcases relationships between purpose and education in four countries: Finland, China, South Korea and two cities in Spain with different cultural backgrounds—Catalan Barcelona and Castilian Madrid.

Chinese and Finnish students encounter purpose dimensions more holistically because purpose is integrated into national curricular frameworks, whereas Korean students tend to address purpose after they have fulfilled their academic duties to get into a good

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university. Purpose is relatively new as an educational focus in Spain, yet it is tied to Spanish youths' growing emphasis on social justice concerns embodying purpose's beyond-the-self dimension.

These articles derive from a nine-university, six-country research collaboration studying the relationship between purpose development and service-learning experiences. The other countries are the US and Brazil, whose work was included in the first issue. I served as the principal investigator of the project, and data collection was centralized through an online portal at my university with language-specific student surveys for each country at three time points corresponding to the start, middle and end of courses.

Collaborators recruited courses and students independently, so students' majors, year in college, demographics, and course discipline and length could vary based on the norms of the university and country. However, based on past assessments of effective service-learning (Astin, Vogelgesang, Ikeda, & Yee, 2000; Clayton, Bringle, & Hatcher, 2013; Eyler, Giles, Stenson, & Gray, 2001), all courses were required to include at least 15 hours of community work during the semester that involved students directly interacting with community beneficiaries not just fundraising or office work.

However, this special issue does not comprise *cross*-cultural studies. Comparative papers across countries in the research collaboration are in production elsewhere (summarized in Moran, 2017a). As editor of this special issue, I took a culturally pluralistic stance and encouraged authors to frame their arguments in terms of their own country's history, current challenges, conceptual interpretations and values. This stance conforms to cultural psychology, cultural-historical psychology and ecological psychology. Cultural psychology focuses on how group members share and cohere specific values, symbols and practices into a way of life to make sense of their own lives (Shweder, 1999). Cultural-historical psychology focuses on how individuals' idiosyncratic meanings and a group's socially agreed-upon meanings interact to stabilize and develop culture over time such that individuals' options to contribute to the culture depend on the state of the culture at the time (Valsiner, 2011). Ecological psychology focuses on how individuals make use of available cultural resources, which depends in part on how individuals' goals and situational constraints interact (Heft, 2013). These perspectives highlight the importance of cultural context when considering purpose development and education.

Prosocial activities like community service have been related to life purpose before (e.g., Bellah, Madsen, Sullivan, Swidler, & Tipton, 1985; Butler & Carr, 1968). But the requirement for purpose to include expected prosocial impact has generated scholarly disagreements (e.g., Waddington, 2010). The opportunity to study service-learning experiences simultaneously in various countries afforded multiple approaches to these disagreements.

Therefore, articles in this issue report additional exploratory analyses of country-specific data addressing secondary research questions of interest to authors and relevant to their cultural context. The specific questionnaires, data collection time points and methods vary. Some studies are the first to be done with these datasets, such as linking Damon's (2008) youth purpose conception and Self-Determination Theory's generally independent conception of aspirations and motivations (e.g., Kasser & Ryan, 1993; Lau et al., 2015); exploring how students' perception of university support for community service relates to different levels of purpose; considering relationships between prosocial and change-oriented life goals on students' expected benefits of their service to the community; and relating emotions about service to changes in students' purpose.

All study samples skew female, from 68% in South Korea to 94% in Finland and Madrid, based on the demographics of students who tend to take service-learning courses in their locales. In addition, three studies on student-teachers emphasize generativity since these future teachers aim for meaningful and prosocial endeavors by following generations. Articles also explore variation *within* countries, as relevant to their research questions. For example, authors made differential use of and inferences from lists of specific life goals and purpose characteristics. Nuances within their different analyses plus these studies collated together in one special issue are valuable to strengthen understanding of culture's roles in purpose and education.

A personal experience of purpose-in-action education

I come to purpose-oriented education as an educational practitioner as well as a researcher. I teach an undergraduate psychology seminar 'What Is My Purpose in Life?' I have learned that purpose is a vague abstraction for students until concrete actions and symbols ground it in real life. Leaping from 'I want to generally help others' to 'I am committing to supporting immigrant children's thriving' to the even more specific 'My life aim is to use arts to stimulate curiosity about cultural differences as opportunities not boundaries,' students tell me that producing representations through arts, diagrams, improvisational skits, and collaborating in the community to effect change clarify where their personally meaningful inclinations align with cultural opportunities. They see they *matter*.

After using three pedagogical approaches to the course, each differently prioritizing Damon's (2008) four dimensions of a developing purpose, community service so far has produced the strongest growth in purpose-oriented thinking and behavior. The first approach of understanding purpose as a *concept* and its relation to other concepts like hope and well-being prioritized meaning and engagement in terms of traditional conceptual understanding and participation in classroom activities. This approach paralleled studies that showed teachers consider personal meaning and engagement as the purpose dimensions more easily producible in the classroom compared to intention and beyond-the-self impact (Moran, 2016b). The second approach of students extracting practical *tools* from purpose research to apply to their own daily decisions and purpose development prioritized engagement in finding and applying tools that resulted in only short-term impacts on other students through peer-coaching. Neither of these first two approaches gained much traction in helping students clarify or strengthen a particular purpose content. Students became more aware of categorical framings of purpose rather than how to develop a specific purpose for themselves. The third approach of *practicing* service work that demonstrates impact on others prioritized the effects of one's actions to produce meaning through feedback from others, which for some led to intention to continue contributing to others. Through practice, since service work is required of everyone, students starting the course with no purpose, searching for purpose, or committed to a specific purpose all could gain insights from feedback on their impacts (Fishbach, Eyal, & Finkelstein, 2010; Moran, 2017b, under review).

I became curious: How have other scholars and educators, especially through other cultural lenses, approached student purpose development through educational means?

Education perpetuates culture

How the abstract concept of purpose is elaborated concretely in a person's life depends in part on where the person lives. Both purpose and education are grounded in cultural values and expectations. Geographical location, family and friendship networks and levels of schooling relate to how purposes are pursued (Grouzet et al., 2005; Massey, Gebhardt, & Garnefski, 2008; see also *Journal of Moral Education* September 2017 special issue).

Educational opportunities help students 'thread' their lives into their culture's 'tapestry' (Moran, 2017c). Education aims to prepare students for '*the* future' (Bundick & Tirri, 2014; Moran, 2016b). But how well does education prepare students for '*their* future' (Malin, Reilly, Quinn, & Moran, 2013; Moran, Bundick, Malin, & Reilly, 2012)? An ongoing challenge in purpose development is how education and purpose play a role in each other's success.

Most youth accept their culture's normative life purposes that are institutionally supported although a few venture to change cultural conventions (Delle Fave, Brdar, Wissing, & Vella-Brodrick, 2013; Moran, 2010, 2015; Nurmi, 1991). Educational institutions are at the center of this enculturation process (Flum & Kaplan, 2006), and there have been calls for educators to increase their role in purpose development (Bundick & Tirri, 2014; Damon, 2008).

Cultures vary in their reasons for devising purpose education. China benefits from two philosophical traditions, Confucianism and Marxism, that reinforce strong connections between personal intention and collective good through formal policy and institutional supports. Finland's infrastructure for 'whole-child' education and social welfare similarly emphasize social interconnectedness. South Korea is undergoing societal change potentially shifting youths' interests toward individualist aims within its traditionally collectivist culture (Shin, Hwang, Cho, & McCarthy-Donovan, 2013), but interactions between personal enjoyment and informative feedback still support prosocial aims. Spain's recent political developments, job instability, and university curricular changes as a European Union member have led young people to consider social change alternatives to traditional life paths.

Function of education in purpose development

Exploratory educational activities can help students searching for a purpose (Malin et al., 2013; Moran, 2016b; Moran et al., 2012; Yeager & Bundick, 2009) clarify what they care about (Yeager et al., 2014) and the legacy they want to make (Moran, 2016b). Conversely, educational activities can help students who already espouse a purpose to select educational opportunities relevant to pursuing their purpose (Malin et al., 2013; Moran, 2016b; Moran et al., 2012).

Articles in this issue address various educational influences on students' purpose. Folgueiras and Palou describe how different models for youths' life trajectory relate to the types of life aims youth may pursue. Jiang and Gao discuss how students perceived university support for prosocial efforts affect students' life purpose in China. Manninen, Kuusisto and Tirri describe how social services training as a helping profession may not always result in socially oriented purposes in students. Kim, Shin, Hwang and Lee describe how teachers' informative feedback can help less motivated students see the value of service work. Opazo, Aramburuzabala and Ramirez share how service-learning courses can change Spanish students' purpose dimensions.

Function of purpose in education

In turn, students' development of life purpose may be fundamental—not ancillary—to education (Tirri, Moran, & Mariano, 2016). Larson's (2006) 'intentionality paradox' proposes students benefit from the psychological momentum of life purpose to scaffold their own learning and life opportunities. Purpose can be a powerful self-regulator for meaning-making and prosocial contribution (Moran, 2017c, in press b; Van Tongeren et al., 2017) that also improves academic work (Yeager & Bundick, 2009; Yeager et al., 2014).

One way to examine how life purpose affects academic learning is to assess the ways that purpose at the start of a course relate to desired outcomes of the course. For example, Kim et al. show how students' initial purpose confidence and commitment relate to their perceived purposeful social contribution after service. Opazo et al. consider relationships students perceive between their initial purpose and their emotional expectations and experiences during service plus how those relationships correlate with changes in their purpose. Folgueiras and Palou focus on how relationships between initial expectations to help others or to change society are expected to benefit strangers. Jiang and Gao focus on three levels of beyond-the-self impact that students may start a course with: self-transcendent emotions, subjective sense of having a life purpose, and specific purpose contents.

Why focus on service-learning?

Service-learning is the most likely educational experience to make salient all four dimensions of purpose because, by definition, it is engagement in actions expected to positively impact others and the common good (Barber, Mueller, & Ogata, 2013; Sanders-Bustle, 2012). Students can reflect on the personal meaning of the service (Araújo, Arantes, Klein, & Grandino, 2014; Stavrova & Luhmann, 2016) that can give rise to intentions for prosocial contributions later in life (Finley, 2011; Hill, Burrow, Brandenberger, Lapsley, & Quaranto, 2010).

Scholarly interest is rising regarding the intersection of community service and life purpose (Damon & Malin, in press; Moran, in press c; Moran & Opazo, 2016). As an empowering beacon for prosocial pursuits, purpose can serve as a repository of intentions and meanings from prior service experiences to steer students toward later opportunities to contribute to their communities and the common good (Etzioni, 2004; Flanagan & Bundick, 2011; Moran, 2017c). Furthermore, service-learning has grown tremendously in many parts of the world so it provides a multicultural vehicle to explore purpose-in-action education (e.g., Aramburuzabala, McIlrath, & Opazo, in press; Haski-Leventhal, Gronlund, Holmes, Meijs, & Zrinscak, 2010).

A feedback-loop model of the reciprocity of purpose and service

Relationships between purpose and service-learning can be summarized in a feedback-loop model. This model was more fully described in the introduction to the first special issue (Moran, 2017c). The model conveys how *perception* of a situation can create opportunities for a person to *act*, which can generate *effects* on others. If those effects ripple beyond the direct beneficiaries, they also affect the *common good*. The common good is a repository of all community members' prosocial contributions that are available for the benefit of

everyone in the community. *Feedback* from one's actions, their effects and the state of the common good can be perceived by the person to again influence whether the person finds opportunities for further contribution. Community service work is an action aimed to have prosocial effects on other individuals and the common good so it is particularly amenable to demonstrating the model (Moran, 2017b, under review).

Even if a student has not already committed to a purpose, community service work could result in feedback on the student's efforts that the student perceives as making a difference in others' well-being, which could generate emotional *meaning* for the student and generate *intentions* to contribute in the future. In addition, repeated interactions of meaning, intention and feedback on prosocial effects could catalyze development of a life purpose. The budding or strengthening of a life purpose shifts a student's perception from passively scanning situations for *general* opportunities to contribute toward actively forging *specific* opportunities to pursue the purpose further. The student becomes more proactive in contributing to others and the community, and being a purposeful contributor becomes increasingly central to the student's personal identity (Moran & Opazo, 2016).

When the student's representation of their life aim becomes more clearly linked to sustenance and growth of the common good—that is, the personal repository of meanings and intentions to 'do good' (i.e., purpose) and the collective repository of aggregated prosocial contributions of all community members (i.e., the common good) feed each other's well-being—then the weaving of the student's individual 'life thread' into the community's 'tapestry' has been completed. The individual is integral to the community and vice versa—the two compose each other (Moran, 2016a). The student has internalized the importance of *mattering* to the community.

Based on the contributions of the studies in this special issue, this feedback model frames several interesting questions to pursue for research in purpose education to move forward: Why is self-transcendence so challenging? Are we looking in the wrong temporal direction for insights? Are callings in the individual or in the role?

Why is self-transcendence so challenging?

Self-transcendence comes in many forms (Yaden, Haidt, Hood, Vago, & Newberg, 2017) and is considered an ideal in many cultures. Yet, many educational courses to generate self-transcendent experiences tend to fail (Waples, Alison, Murphy, Connelly, & Mumford, 2009). Articles in this special issue suggest life purposes that transcend self-interest are difficult for many students. Manninen et al.'s findings that even Finnish students in a decidedly prosocial profession may not personally endorse the beyond-the-self reasons for such work and instead are motivated by personal happiness. Helping others is instrumental to a stable career for oneself rather than a vehicle for contributing to the common good. Similarly, Jiang and Gao's study of Chinese student-teachers, even though targeted toward self-transcendent emotions, fundamentally investigated how students perceived personal benefits of their life goals resulting from university support *to* the students. This is a relatively common occurrence in the service-learning literature—an emphasis on benefits to students rather than to community members the students aim to help (D'Arlach, Sanchez, & Feuer, 2009). In addition, the university support primarily reduced negative self-transcendent emotions like disgust rather than lifting positive emotions like awe. Even members of collectivist cultures may consider that a focus on benefits to the whole community feels like

an imposed duty rather than a voluntary contribution, such as how some Korean youth felt in a prior study (Shin et al., 2013).

The Spain-based studies provide a different perspective on self-transcendence. The Catalan study emphasized the need for self-transcendence due to challenging societal circumstances. An alternative to the standard model of 'the good life' has become increasingly viable and desired as college students realize helping others and changing the world are different aspects of the same collective goal to alleviate suffering from poor economic prospects. The Madrid study addressed self-transcendence through the expected cross-generational effects of student-teachers. These students felt inspired and determined, increasing the helpfulness and personal meaningfulness of their life purposes to mitigate the stresses of teaching. Yet, their purposes strengthened their orientation toward self-benefits as well.

It is surprising how even helping-oriented professions and collectivist cultures show self-centered tendencies (e.g., Massey et al., 2008). This 'problem of self-interest' (Waddington, 2010) suggests that educational experiences to benefit others must be conceptualized as moral enactments rather than just transactional duties for credit or awards. Furthermore, these moral enactments may need to concentrate on benefiting others whom the person does not know, not just family and friends as is often the case in many cultures (including Finland, China and Barcelona in this issue). Other studies suggest that the challenge of self-transcendence requires integration of the common good into personal meaning so that the two cannot be posited as opposites (Delle Fave et al., 2013).

Callings: Is purpose in the individual or the role?

Several of this issue's articles use samples of student-teachers. Teachers report being drawn to teaching from a young age (Flores & Niklasson, 2014; Moran, 2016b) and being purposeful in their work (Tirri & Ubani, 2013). Furthermore, teachers have an important cultural role in bridging generations as they assimilate the next generation into cultural norms, values and practices (Tirri & Ubani, 2013). Opazo et al. explicitly mention that teaching is often considered a calling.

Individuals with callings feel drawn to a role or field by emotional and existential reasons rather than for financial or advancement rewards (Wrzesniewski, McCauley, Rozin, & Schwartz, 1997). They integrate their work and lives and, perhaps most importantly for this special issue, they infuse their work with a social or moral significance (Bellah et al., 1985). A calling resembles intrinsic motivation in being self-driven. Yet, a calling need not involve enjoyment of the work, only that the work is important for a greater good. An example is the conversation of two bricklayers, one who saw the job as tediously stacking bricks and mortar, whereas the other considered the work critical to building a cathedral that could last centuries. The second had a calling.

A calling makes salient the social value of one's efforts, solidifying the beyond-the-self dimension of purpose as an internalized duty. If one is called to a particular role or social need, then it can feel like an internal validation or rightness of one's intent—a passion that one feels compelled to follow even if one must suffer for the beloved (Dobrow Riza & Heller, 2015; Moran, 2009, 2010). Callings transform work from a life requirement into a meaningful blessing and, even if initially felt as a magnet to something outside oneself, eventually become fused into self-fulfillment (Ponton et al., 2014). In addition, a calling can

make individuals perceive they have stronger abilities, even absent objective indicators of actual ability, which motivates them to engage their purpose longer (Dobrow Riza & Heller, 2015) and can generate humility or awe (e.g., Bronk, 2008; Yaden et al., 2017).

Kim et al. and Opazo et al. both explore feedback mechanisms in service work, such as emotions and information. Since students enter service experiences at different stages of purpose development, feedback on their efforts may impact their further purpose development in different ways (Fishbach et al., 2010; Moran, 2017b, under review). Connecting service to a calling may be how teachers' informative feedback, as Kim et al. report, influences purpose even if intrinsic motivation at first is weak. Using the feedback-loop model, perhaps a calling changes the entry point of a student into purpose development. Feeling a calling may remove the need for some students to receive feedback before they commit to a prosocial cause. Students with previous service experience already may have developed personal meanings and future intentions to continue—i.e., they have a nascent purpose which filters their perception of further opportunities to serve based on that purpose. Other students may be motivated to perceive opportunities to serve because they already enjoy helping others or see themselves as helper persons (Moran, 2017b, under review). But for students without a purpose or prior service experience, they enter the feedback loop through the first act of service, which generates effects that may lead to perceptible feedback. Some of these students, soon after starting their service, may feel a calling. They may be more sensitive to the community need or to the potential ripple effects of the service work even before receiving feedback on their own efforts. They have an insight, recognize the common good in a personally meaningful way, and just 'know' that this specific type of work is 'why I am here' (Yeager & Bundick, 2009). More research can tease apart these interactions.

Yet, the idea of a calling presents a nagging question. Does the calling adhere to only specific roles (Dik & Duffy, 2009)? Religious leaders and teachers are most often noted as professions with callings, but many helping professionals also describe a sense of calling, as Manninen et al. suggest social services professionals in Finland do. Creative professionals also sometimes convey their work as a calling (Moran, 2009). Or does the calling arise from the individual regardless of the role they take? The earlier example of the cathedral bricklayers support this second option, as does the heartwarming story of the dancing toll taker who understood his role not as taking money to allow drivers to cross a bridge but rather as an opportunity to practice dancing in a beautiful setting overlooking San Francisco bay and share his love of life with harried motorists who don't expect a positive experience during their commute (Garfield, 1987). On this view, a calling is an attitude toward one's efforts that can apply to any role. How could this attitude be cultivated and reinforced not only in service-learning but other forms of education? How can educators emphasize that students' efforts matter and that contributions by all roles—not only teachers or pastors—can be important to the well-being of future generations? For example, activities that produce stories depicting meaningful insights about oneself tend to relate to cross-generational impact and ongoing social contributions (Daloz, Keen, Keen, & Park, 1996; Lawford & Ramey, 2015).

Are we looking in the wrong temporal direction for insights?

Reflecting on one's past experiences is a cornerstone of experiential and service-learning (Selmo, 2015). Reflection processes what happened (Astin et al., 2000) by attributing

personal meaning to one's actions and effects on others (Clayton et al., 2013), discovering deeper patterns of reasoning that help students overcome habitual ways of thinking (Argyris, 1991). But from a purpose perspective, reflection is 'driving by the rear-view mirror' (Moran, 2016a), focusing students on where they have been rather than where they are headed (Seligman, Railton, Baumeister, & Sripada, 2013). Reflection may sensitize perception or categorization but fails to imagine other possibilities for purposeful behavior (Moran, 2014a, in press a). Purpose provides a representation of the future that can guide choices in the present toward making that representation more likely. Instead of *re*flecting or bending backward on yesterday, purpose encourages students to *pro*flect, bending forward into tomorrow (Moran, 2014a, 2016a).

When caught up only in self-interest, imagining one's future can become solipsistic or detached (Narvaez & Mrkva, 2014). This is akin to understanding one's life through a mirror rather than through a window. By embracing a beyond-the-self orientation, proflection generates ethical anticipation (Moran, 2016a). Anticipation is an approach-focused emotion like hope that motivates possibilities (see Burrow, O'Dell, & Hill, 2010). Ethical anticipation harnesses moral imagination to perceive everyday occurrences as potential opportunities to do good for others, the community and the common good. Moral imagination offers flexibility to include others' perspectives within one's considerations, which encourages creativity (Grant & Berry, 2011). From this view, purpose is a creative act of the moral imagination to project oneself into the community and into the future as a prosocial force (Moran, 2016a).

Perhaps what is needed to support both self-transcendence and callings are two strategies: (1) more educational support to develop students' imagination so they can see the latent opportunities 'hiding in plain sight' (Moran, 2016a); and (2) reconceiving the relationship of self and other not as a boundary but as an extension, encouraging students to entertain different perspectives as opportunities to change their own minds and expand their meaning-making through social connection (Moran, in press a, in press b; Stavrova & Luhmann, 2016).

Articles in this special issue support these proposals. Aiming to benefit strangers and future generations requires imagining what-could-be within the perceptions of what-currently-is. Findings from the two Spanish studies both associate prosocial aims with creativity and thinking beyond current models of social organization. Interestingly, Opazo et al. note two surprising findings: several students' purposes strengthened in self-care/self-benefit, and purpose change was associated with mitigating *negative* emotions from service, which could be viewed as a self-protective mechanism. Similarly, Jiang and Gao note how China's educational system currently aims to expand student creativity, yet university support did not boost positive self-transcendence emotions but rather mitigated negative self-transcendent emotions, again a potential self-protective mechanism.

Manninen et al. note that reflection by itself, even within a prosocial professional role, may not help students understand their contributions to the common good, so they may only consider short-term feedback that benefits themselves. Similarly, Kim et al. note how Korean students rarely consider prosocial purposes until college because they focus on more immediate benefits of academic achievement, and simply doing volunteering acts without effective feedback may not stimulate prosocial purpose in students. If Kim et al.'s suggestion that the perspectives of others are necessary for students to integrate their current prosocial actions into a meaningful future life path, and students could be coached to

internalize those important perspectives within their own imaginations, this internalized faculty of wider perspective-taking parallels the integration of all four of Damon's purpose dimensions into a self-regulating contributor to one's cultural development (Moran, 2015, in press a; Moran & Gardner, 2018).

Moving forward

As explorations of various ways cultures interweave their members' purposeful contributions into a common good, both this special issue and the first special issue on youth purpose from an international perspective bring much needed curiosity and interest to cultural nuances regarding purpose development. Where might we go from here? Indigenously created measures and coding schemes rather than translated versions from other countries would be a good start. Although using the same measures across contexts may provide measurement invariance for statistical analyses, such research designs also can hide interesting cultural insights on purpose. Several articles in this issue demonstrate context-dependent interpretations of specific purpose contents, and several articles in the first issue introduce context-dependent interpretations of purpose dimensions, expressions and categories (e.g., Balthip et al., 2017; Kawai & Moran, 2017; Mason, 2017).

The implications discussed in this introduction call for more work to reconsider the notions of self and beyond-the-self, perhaps as a continuum or spectrum rather than categories: is there really a border at all? Categorical distinctions, such as self vs. other, individual vs. role, intrinsic vs. duty-bound callings, and past vs. future meaning-making may provide interesting scholarly insights from an objective perspective. But they may be counterproductive to the actual development of purpose in young people because life is lived forward as subjective experience. Purpose is a chosen life direction to gain momentum in contributing to the common good in a personally meaningful way. Perhaps education for purpose development could emphasize curricula that interweaves individual subjective sense-making and cultural shared meanings so students can envision contributions to their communities as important threads within a larger tapestry. Given plenty of opportunities to practice and receive real-world feedback on how they positive affect others, these interwoven threads compose the common good that supports us all.

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